114. The proposed general instructions prescribe the order of information in the annual report. Is requiring a specific order for that information appropriate? Should the order be changed? If so, how? For instance, are there certain items that funds should disclose earlier (or later) in the report to be more consistent with shareholders' general areas of interest? Should we, for example, require disclosure of material fund changes earlier in the report? Does the proposed order of disclosure items appropriately place related items close together, or are there changes we could make to improve a shareholder's ability to understand how different disclosure items relate to one another?

115. Would the proposed general instruction that directs funds to comply with legibility requirements assist investors by helping to promote the readability of shareholder reports? Are there other requirements that we should include to assist investors with the readability of shareholder reports?

116. Are there other alternative ways of presenting information that we should encourage funds to consider using?

4. Electronic Annual Reports

We recognize that fund shareholders may access their annual reports and other regulatory documents online, rather than (or in addition to) receiving the reports in paper format. Shareholders could elect to receive their annual reports through electronic delivery.[327] Additionally, under our proposal, funds that rely either on rule 498 or on proposed rule 498B would have to make the most recent annual report available online.[328] We also recognize that

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[327] Under this proposal, shareholder reports must be delivered in paper unless, consistent with Commission guidance, a shareholder elects electronic delivery. *See supra* footnote 21 and accompanying text.

[328] *See infra* Sections II.F.3.a and II.J.

investors are increasingly relying on mobile applications for financial information, and we anticipate that funds may wish to make annual reports available in a format that these applications support (for example, electronic presentations other than a static email or PDF file). Presenting fund information—including annual reports—electronically has the potential advantage of permitting greater innovation and information-tailoring than the use of a static paper document. For example, funds could overlay electronic tools onto online disclosure, such as calculators, hover-over or pop-up information, and interactive features. Presenting information electronically could also improve the content of fund disclosures by, for example, allowing investors to customize certain fund disclosures, such as fees, expenses, and performance, based on an investor's individual circumstances. However, we appreciate that the use of electronic channels, and the overlay of electronic tools onto required regulatory documents, may present both practical and legal questions for fund registrants and other market participants.[329]

In light of this, we are proposing instructions that are designed to clarify requirements for electronic annual reports and to promote the use of interactive, user-friendly design features that may be tailored to meet individual investors' needs and improve investor engagement. We are tailoring certain proposed instructions to reflect that annual reports may be electronic as well as paper-based. First, the proposed requirements for the annual report's

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[329] For example, the legal requirements associated with a particular online tool may vary based on what information is present and how it is presented. We discuss these issues in more detail below. In addition, it may be costly to produce, maintain and update electronic tools and produce tools that function well on a variety of devices (such as phones, tablets and computers).

"cover page" are also applicable to the "beginning" of the report, which is designed to reflect that electronic reports may not have a physical page at their beginning.[330] Similarly, the proposed instruction that would provide an ordering requirement for the contents of an annual report also includes a provision for annual reports that appear on a website or are otherwise provided electronically.[331] This proposed instruction specifies that information should be organized in a manner that gives each item similar prominence, and presents the information in the same order, as that provided by the order the proposed instruction prescribes. For instance, an annual report available on a website could satisfy this requirement if each required disclosure item is presented with equal prominence in a separate tab and the order of the tabs follows the prescribed order, such as from left-to-right or top-to-bottom. Similarly, a mobile application could satisfy this requirement if the shareholder report navigation screen presents each shareholder report item with equal prominence and follows the prescribed order of information.[332]

We are also proposing instructions that would provide additional flexibility for funds to add additional tools and features to annual reports that appear on a website or are otherwise provided electronically.[333] The proposed instructions would encourage funds to use online tools designed to enhance an investor's understanding of material in the annual reports. This could include, for example: video or audio messages, mouse-over windows, pop-up

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330 *See supra* footnote 136.

331 *See* Instruction 1 to proposed Item 27A(a) of Form N-1A.

332 *See infra* footnotes 338-340 and related discussion regarding the recordkeeping and record retention requirements associated with such electronic tools.

333 *See* Instruction 8 to proposed Item 27A(a) of Form N-1A.

definitions or explanations of difficult concepts, chat functionality, and expense calculators. It also includes other forms of electronic media, communications, or tools designed to enhance an investor's understanding of material in the annual report. For example, this could include the ability to customize expense, performance or holdings information, or to make performance information more interactive.[334] We believe that permitting and encouraging these design features would allow for a more interactive and user-friendly experience and would improve investor engagement. When using interactive graphics or tools, funds are permitted to include instructions on their use and interpretation.[335] In addition, the proposed general instructions clarify that any explanatory or supplemental information that funds provide as online tools may not obscure or impede understanding of the required disclosures.[336]

The default presentation of the content of any electronically presented annual report must use the value that the applicable requirement under Item 27A prescribes.[337] For example, while the default presentation in the expense example and performance line graph must be on a $10,000 assumed investment, a feature may permit an investor to enter a different amount but the investor must, as a default, be able to view the assumed amount.[338] One result of this

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334 For example, one feature may be the ability to hover over a point on the performance line graph to see the date and dollar value associated with that point.

335 *See* Instruction 10 to proposed Item 27A(a) of Form N-1A.

336 *See id*. (providing that any supplemental information may not, because of the nature, quantity, or manner of presentation, obscure or impede understanding of the information that must be included).

337 *See* Instruction 8 to proposed Item 27A(a) of Form N-1A.

338 *See* Item 27A(c) and (d) of Form N-1A.

instruction would be that when the contents of a fund's annual reports are derived from the fund's audited financial statements, the default online presentation would be the audited figures.

Under the general instructions we are proposing, any information that is included in online tools that the fund uses, but that is not included in the annual report that the fund files on Form N-CSR, would have the same status under the Federal securities laws as any other website or other electronic content that the fund produces or disseminates.[339] For example, if a fund includes a video providing more detail about the fund's investments and performance, the video may, based on the facts and circumstances, be an advertisement subject to rule 482.[340] Under these circumstances, the fund would be subject to the same liability standard and filing requirements that attach to any other rule 482 advertisement. This proposed instruction is designed to remind funds about liability and any filing requirements associated with any additional information that a fund chooses to include with the online version of its annual report (other than the shareholder report information that it files with the Commission on Form N-CSR). This supplemental information would also be subject to a record retention requirement.[341]

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339 *See* Instruction 8 to proposed Item 27A(a) of Form N-1A. That instruction would provide, in part: "Any information that is not included in the annual or semi-annual shareholder report filed on Form N-CSR shall have the same status, under the Federal securities laws, as any other website or electronic content that the Fund produces or disseminates."

340 17 CFR 230.482. An investment company advertisement that complies with rule 482 is deemed to be a section 10(b) prospectus for purpose of section 5(b)(1) of the Securities Act. As a section 10(b) prospectus, an investment company advertisement is subject to liability under section 12(a)(2) of the Securities Act and the antifraud provisions of the Federal securities laws.

341 Section 31(a) of the Investment Company Act imposes recordkeeping obligations on registered investment companies, and also requires that each investment adviser (that is not a

Finally, we are proposing an instruction providing that if the shareholder report references other information that is available online, the report should include a link or some other means of immediately accessing that information.[342] The proposed instruction states that, for example, the fund should provide hyperlinks to the fund's prospectus and financial statements if the information is available online. The proposed instruction also states that, in an annual report that is delivered in paper format, funds may include website addresses, QR codes, or other means of providing access to such information.[343] We believe these approaches are consistent with a layered approach to disclosure, and that providing ready access to the information that a shareholder report references (but does not directly include) would be a convenient feature for investors. Under these requirements, a fund must include a link specific enough to lead investors directly to a specific item or alternatively to a central site with prominent links to the referenced information. For example, a reference to a fund's prospectus could include a direct link to the prospectus or might include a link to the landing page that includes prominent links to several fund documents, such as the summary

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majority-owned subsidiary), depositor, and principal underwriter for a registered investment company maintain and preserve such records as the Commission shall prescribe to record that person's transactions with the registered investment company. The Commission prescribes those recordkeeping requirements under rules 31a-1 and 31a-2. Specifically, rule 31a-1 provides the records that a registered investment company must maintain; rule 31a-2 provides the retention period for those records.

To address funds' retention of any supplemental information that a fund chooses to include in its online version of its annual report (other than the shareholder report information that the fund files with the Commission on Form N-CSR), we are proposing a conforming change to rule 31a-2 that would require that every investment company: "Preserve for a period not less than six years, the first two years in an easily accessible place, any shareholder report required by §270.30e-1 (including any version posted on a website or otherwise provided electronically) that is not filed with the Commission in the exact form in which it was used." *See* proposed rule 31a-2(a)(7).

342 *See* Instruction 9 to proposed Item 27A(a) of Form N-1A.

343 *See id*.

prospectus, prospectus, SAI and annual reports. However, the link cannot lead investors to a home page or section of the fund's website other than on which the specified item is posted. This proposed requirement is designed to permit the investor easily to locate (*i.e.,* without numerous clicks) the information in which he or she is interested.

We request comment on the proposed general instructions regarding electronic annual reports, including:

117. Are the proposed instructions that are designed to reflect that annual reports may be electronic as well as paper-based appropriate? Specifically, would the requirements for the "beginning" of the shareholder report clarify the contents that the Commission would require to appear first in electronically presented annual reports? Similarly, is the proposed instruction permitting an "equivalent" order (to that prescribed in Form N-1A) for annual reports that appear on a website or are otherwise provided electronically (such as a mobile application) appropriate, and is this instruction clear? If not, why not? Are there any other instructions that would help clarify content and format requirements for electronic annual reports?

118. The proposed general instructions would encourage a fund to use online tools for annual reports that are available electronically. Would this proposed instruction help to explain the content required to be included in the annual report? Is permitting the additional information conveyed by these tools appropriate? Should there be any limits on the types of additional information that funds present along with electronic versions of their annual reports, in addition to the limits prescribed by the proposed instructions (*e.g.*, that explanatory or supplemental information be responsive to the proposed shareholder report content requirements, that it not be misleading or impede understanding of the required disclosures,

and that the default presentation contents in electronically presented shareholder reports be based on the same assumptions required by Item 27A)? For instance, should we permit a fund's expense presentation to include an explanation that compares a fund's expenses to its peer group?

119. The federal securities laws generally do not prohibit a fund from posting a version of its annual or semi-annual shareholder report translated into a foreign language on its website.[344] Further, we understand that funds occasionally will include online tools, such as translators, on their websites to assist non-English speaking investors and investors with disabilities to assess information about the fund. Should the Commission address the translation of a shareholder report or other documents filed with the Commission (such as a prospectus) into a foreign language and the transmission of those documents to shareholders? If so, what factors should the Commission consider? Should the Commission address foreign language shareholder reports (and foreign language versions of other fund regulatory materials) not only for open-end funds, but also other types of funds? If the Commission were to amend its rules to address the transmission of foreign language shareholder reports, should it also require foreign language versions of shareholder reports to be filed with the Commission?

120. As proposed, any additional information that a fund presents in connection with an electronic version of its annual report that is not included in the annual report filed on Form N-CSR would have the same status under the Federal securities laws as any other

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[344] *See supra* paragraph accompanying footnotes 339 through 341 and accompanying text (discussing the status under the Federal securities laws of information that funds include on their websites).

website or electronic content that the fund produces or disseminates. Is this approach appropriate? Notwithstanding this proposed instruction, should we require a fund to file this additional information with the Commission? If so, why, and through what channels should funds be required to file the additional information (*e.g.*, on Form N-CSR)? Is it appropriate to provide investors additional information online that would not have to be provided in paper to investors who request paper documents? If not, why not?

121. Is it appropriate to require that any electronic version of an annual report provide a means of facilitating access (such as a hyperlink) to any information that is referenced in the annual report that is available online? If not, why not? Similarly, is it appropriate to permit an annual report that is delivered in paper to include website addresses, QR codes, or other means of facilitating access to such information? Should the use of website addresses and QR codes be required for annual reports delivered in paper?

122. As proposed, the additional explanatory or supplemental information permitted in an electronic annual report may not, because of the nature, quantity, or manner of presentation, obscure or impede understanding of the information that must be included. Are these restrictions appropriate? If not, why not? Should this instruction also specify that any explanatory or supplemental information that funds provide as online tools be responsive to the proposed content requirements for shareholder reports? Could this additional restriction prevent funds from providing information that some shareholders might find useful? Or would it be helpful in furthering the goal of ensuring that explanatory or supplemental information not obscure understanding of the required disclosures?

123. Rather than what we are proposing, should funds be able to transmit multiple-series annual reports to shareholders but be required to provide tools for tailoring the online

presentation of the disclosure to an individual series? Should we require multi-class funds to provide tools for tailoring the online presentation of the disclosure to an individual class? Why or why not?

124. When a fund's annual report is available on a website or otherwise available electronically, should the investor be warned when he or she leaves the annual report content and moves to other fund content? If so, why? Should all annual report content (particularly when shown on multiple pages or tabs), be clearly identified as being part of the annual report? If not, why not?

125. Do the proposed general instructions sufficiently encourage electronic design and delivery of the annual report? Are the general instructions sufficiently flexible to permit delivery on phones, tablets, and other devices and to accommodate information conveyed via videos, interactive graphics, or tools and calculators? How can the Commission encourage funds to make fuller use of innovative technology to enable more interactive, user-friendly annual reports?

C. Semi-Annual Shareholder Report

We are proposing to specify the design and content of funds' semi-annual reports through new Item 27A of Form N-1A. These design and content specifications are similar to those we are proposing for funds' annual reports.[345]

The table below summarizes the proposed content that funds would include in their semi-annual reports and compares the proposal to current semi-annual report disclosure requirements.

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[345] *See supra* section II.B.